

His Name is KHAN

A stand-off with the Shiv Sena and a new film re-establish the star's credentials as a hero of our troubled times

By Kaveree Bamzai

Sitting in Christmas ice-cold Berlin, with just a few hours to go before *My Name is Khan* was to release in Mumbai, Shah Rukh Khan decided to open a bottle of wine in the Regent Hotel room and share it with friend and director Karan Johar. After a sleepless fortnight, it was a time for reflection, and how even as the 60th International Film Festival of Berlin was getting ready to have him grace the red carpet for the screening of *My Name is Khan* and greet the enthusiastic cheering of 20,000 fans, there was a cloud hanging over its release in Mumbai. Mumbai, the city where in 1991, Khan had come to settle to make something of his life. A city where the Shiv Sena was

protesting against his remarks on how humiliating it was to see no Pakistani players selected for the IPL. A city where his posters had been defaced, his effigies burnt, and his patriotism questioned. A city where threats were pronounced that would overshadow his heart-stopping performance in the film as Rizvan Khan, a cosmetics-salesman-cum-repairman who suffers from Asperger's Syndrome, and whose life changes dramatically after 9/11.

Released this weekend, the film, which is exuberant but simplistic in parts, has quickly made \$19 million worldwide in the first weekend, making it the biggest Shah Rukh

opening in India as well as the biggest Bollywood opening weekend in the UK and the US. More than that, his unbending stand against the Shiv Sena made watching *My Name is Khan* a badge of honour for anyone who believes in a more liberal India. Having stood his ground, though, Shah Rukh has not even had the time to say "yippee". Partly because of physical exhaustion, given a gruelling schedule that has seen him go from Nasdaq in New York to the Emirates Palace in Abu Dhabi, from London where he appeared on Jonathan Ross's *Friday Night* show to Berlin where his billboards stand alongside movies such as Martin Scorsese's

“I’ve always prided myself on being articulate but I think this may have taught me to be quiet, to speak my mind only on matters that concern me.”